STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 19 · Lay It Down

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey, come on and sit. It does me good to see this room full. Uh, some of you walked in already spent. You came anyway. That matters to me. Last lesson we stayed on knowing her. Uh, really knowing her. Or, if there is no wife yet, on the life you already have, not the one you're waiting to start. A few of you went home and asked something true. And a few of you reorganized a drawer and called it progress. I have called worse things progress. So. This lesson costs. You can learn a woman for a long time and still keep your own life clenched. You can— you can fill a house with good things and leave her alone in it. I know that one. I've been the man who studied the problem and kept himself. Interest in her is not the same thing as your life put down on the table. I have, uh, been curious and comfortable. Headship is a cross. You can be right and lay it down. What she actually needs is you, ahead of any upgrade of what you produce. She needs you.

Stay with me. Hear it as one job. You lay your life down, and you deal with what she has been missing while you were, uh, busy being useful. Some of you don't have her in the house. You still belong in this. The cross is not parked at a wedding. There is already a person in reach whose good runs a different direction from yours. A lot of us heard a verse aimed at a wife and we got very brave about it. We got quieter when the lines turned and found the husband. That's where this lesson is. If the leading you prefer still leaves you intact, it isn't His kind. You can't lay a life down until you admit you've been keeping it.

You've carried one sentence through this room. I say it the same way every time. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Uh, you've heard them in this room. Uh, we are not rebuilding them in this lesson. Same four, if you are single, if the marriage ended, if you are young, if you have been at this a long time. The cross does not wait on a wife before it calls your name. I have— I have wanted the say-so. I have treated the costly part as a verse for a more serious day. The serious day is an ordinary house. Stop waiting. That includes the man who quits the work and calls the quitting kindness. Pick up the weight. Uh, stay when vanishing would feel cleaner. Go first. A life set down on purpose, where the people in it can feel it. And work for God's pay. The nod you get when the work goes well is a thin thing. The Father sees what a room does not grade.

Now the claim, plain. Headship is a cross. Men want the authority of Ephesians five without the giving up of Ephesians five. You can be right and lay it down, and that is the marriage. She does not need more of what you make. She needs you.

If you only hear that you'd die for your people, you'll nod, and you'll keep the life. Dying inside a story is easy to admire. I mean the actual evening. The last word you won't release. The phone still in your hand. The hours you decided were yours because your name is on the payment. They look small. They are the cross with your shoes still on.

Put your ear on the verse. Ephesians five, verse twenty-five. Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her.

Gave himself up. All the way, on purpose, while the people He loved were still failing Him. You don't get a softer pattern because your day ran long. Uh, gave himself up is not a mood you visit on a hard night and take your life back in the morning. It is the shape of an ordinary day. Her good, chosen, while you still had a case. Uh, Paul had already written to wives. A lot of men can say that part in their sleep. The next lines run longer. They weigh more. They have our name on them. I have treated those lines as a footnote. You feel strong, you know, when the verse is somebody else's obedience. You feel exposed when it turns and asks for your life. Uh, stay exposed. That's the honest place. Philippians two, verse four. Not looking to your own interests but each of you to the interests of the others.

Her interests. Yours, dressed in a kinder word, still counts as yours. Paul says, have this mindset, the mindset of Christ Jesus. Being in very nature God, He did not consider equality with God something to be used to his own advantage. He made himself nothing.

He had— he had higher ground than any husband here will ever stand on. He did not cash it in for comfort. So when you are right, uh, and the winning line is sitting in your mouth, that mind is the one you reach for. If the leading you admire leaves you whole and comfortable, you are managing a result. He laid a life down. You can't hand Him a speech and call it the same thing.

Let me tell on myself. Uh, we got crossways over the thermostat. I was right. I had the little booklet that came with the unit. Uh, the setting printed in it was the correct one. She was cold. I didn't ask how cold. I read— I read the booklet out loud, in the kitchen, as if I had discovered weather. She went and got a sweatshirt. She didn't fight me. The rest of the evening got very polite. I won the number on the wall. I lost the woman in the room. I slept fine that night. That's how I knew I'd missed it. She was still awake in the sweatshirt, being polite to a man who had won. How many of you have won and felt the house go quiet right after? Go on. I'm not writing names. Yeah. That's a lot of hands. Uh, the facts can stay where they are. I was right about the unit. The unit was never the marriage. I took a small true thing and I stretched it over the whole night. You will be right, you know. Some mornings you'll be right before the coffee. What it costs her to live beside the win, that cost is the part I kept skipping. Uh, put the winning line down. You do it because you love her. That's a better reason than loving the win. She has a name for the face I make when I'm right. She calls it the little seminar. I have delivered a few. Short ones. Strong opinions. Weak fruit. Here's the sentence I wish had come out of me. I'm sorry I made you small so I could stay tall. We can walk it without a winner. A man who can set down a fight he is winning becomes a man she can hand the truth to. A man who takes every point teaches her to shrink the story before she ever says it.

Most of this will not arrive as a big sacrifice. It shows up on an ordinary afternoon. Uh, she'll remember it. You might not. I stood— I stood on our porch after work and cleared every little banner on my phone before I touched the door. She met me with news about one of the kids. I said, I'm listening. Uh, my thumb kept moving. She quit halfway through the story. I caught it on the way to the sink. Another evening I changed clothes slow, door mostly shut, buying a strip of hallway that was only mine. She started knocking. In her own hall. A guest knocks that way. And in the car I had a doctrine. Driver picks the station. I said it as if it was printed in the vows. She stopped offering songs.

I called the quiet peace. It was a small crown, you know, every mile. Then the plan. I told my brother, on a call, we might move towns. I had not said a word of it to my wife. She heard the shape of it from him at a birthday cookout, over a paper plate. I had built a next year in a talk she wasn't in, and I called that leading. Uh, look at your hands a second. Just an honest look.

Whatever you grip hardest, your hands already know the path. The last word. The hours you think you purchased. The rest you guard while she runs thin. The numbers you carry alone. The day you protect when the house is asking. When your mom and your wife don't see it the same, say the kind no, and say it to your mom with respect still in it. Your wife ought to hear which house you stand in. You can't lay a life down until you say which life you've been keeping.

Let me tell you about a man named Mitch. Uh, I've known him a long time. Useful man. The one you text when something has sagged. We were out back, resetting a gate that had dropped. His wife, Paula, came out with tea. She wasn't sharp about it. She said, you're getting him while he still has a voice. I get what's left of a useful man.

Mitch heard every word. He had a screwdriver in his hand and, uh, nothing ready to say. That was new for him. He almost— he almost explained himself. The gate was for her. The yard was for the kids. He had done the thing he knows, which is finish. He didn't give the speech. He stood there with the tool. Later he told me he sat in a lawn chair until the light was gone. Inside meant a question. Outside meant one more thing to complete. Uh, he went in. He asked her, plain, what do you need from me that you're not getting?

She didn't hunt for an answer. Stop finishing things I didn't ask you to finish. Come sit down while you still have something left. He wanted, you know, to correct her. A finished thing passes for love if love has mostly meant output. He kept his mouth shut, and it cost him. He was not a new man by breakfast. He started in on a broken toaster, because a toaster is easier than a face. She looked at him. He set the tool on the counter. Uh, he sat on the rug. He asked what was worrying her before he reported what he had fixed. Some time later, Paula said to me, he still fixes things. He asks which things I actually want. That is a life laid down. In a house he had already paid for. A little of his pride still on the rug.

Now don't grab the wrong version and feel holy. Uh, a man can sound low and be gone. He stops deciding. He stops going first. He lets the hard talk with a kid sit in her lap, and he calls the whole arrangement trust. She feels the empty space on the days she gets what she asked for. That is— that is not a laid-down life. That is leaving, with a soft voice laid over it. Christ gave Himself up, and He kept leading. He did not walk off from the people He loved and name the silence humility. A steadfast man stops waiting. Right in that spot. You've felt that quiet, right? The house goes still, and you're proud of the still. It might be peace. It might be a man who left and stayed inside. There's another counterfeit. The man who will not tell her a true thing. He smiles, he agrees, and then he goes cold and stays cold, because he swallowed a no he owed her. Jesus said hard true things, you know, to people He loved. Uh, love listens first. Then love speaks, gentle and plain, at the hour that actually fits. Uh, if you never speak, you have set the assignment on a shelf. One more fake shows up in this kind of room. You sand yourself down until the house is calm and the man is missing. She married someone with a spine and a direction. Put the pride down. Put the comfort down. Uh, keep a self. She

needs one. After you set a thing down, run one test. Is she more herself, or did she pick up what you dropped? If she stands a little straighter, you loved her. If her load got heavier and you feel spiritual, you left.

I have worn that one. I called it peace when I had stopped showing up to the part that had my name on it.

Come around the corner with me. Laying it down is half the job. The other half is her actual good. If the gift would have felt great landing on you, take that as a clue. A weak one. She needs you. More of what you make will not close what is open.

Start with steadiness. She needs to know you are staying. Uh, some of you keep an exit you've never said. You call it realism. She can— she can feel the draft. Say it so she can hear it. I'm not going anywhere. Whatever this is, we're in it. Then keep it on a day when leaving looks easy. Then presence. Uh, be home while you are home. Ask, uh, and take the whole answer, including the part you were already finishing. She can tell a man who arrived from a man who only passed the door. I told her we were fine about a bill, so I could stay padded. She needed the number, and an open face. Safety next. Most of you won't harm her with your hands. I mean the other harm. I shut down and called it self-control. She started cutting her sentences shorter so I would not go dark. If she has to manage you before she speaks, she is braced in her own kitchen. Give her a gentle answer. Get the heat out of her kitchen. God can hold it. A brother can. Then tell her what you were actually afraid of. Words, out loud, particular enough that they could only be hers. If children are in the house, let them hear you honor her. And lead, so the map is not hers alone. Uh, say where the house is headed. Step into the hard call first, and own it if it goes poorly. Pray with her, out loud, her name in your mouth before God. A room changes when she hears you talk to Him about her.

Then you ask. Not a hint she has to decode. A plain question. What do you need from me that you're not getting?

You will want to defend yourself. Uh, you will want to turn her words into a project you can finish before dark, because finishing passes for love if you are built the way I am built. Don't translate her. Uh, hear the whole answer. Do the first thing she names while her words are still warm. Your face will cost you more than the task. Uh, there is a sentence men dodge. It isn't a verse. It's what she would say to her sister if her sister asked how he's doing, and she answered before she cleaned it up. Write it the way a kitchen would hear it, not the way an introduction would. Write the sentence you are afraid of. If the marriage has ended, write the one she would have used. If there is no wife, write what a person close to you would say on a day he was not protecting your name. Mine would run about this way. He loves his people in jobs. Ask him how he is, and you will get a report. That one scares me, you know, because it has been true. Her answer will not match Paula's. Ask anyway. When the answer comes, don't sand the edges off it. A man can ask a clean question, I mean, and then argue until the question dies. He walks away intact. The face was the costly part, and he kept it. If you're— if you're single, the question still stands. Ask it of somebody already in your life. Then do the first thing that person names. You are building the man now, on days nobody is handing you a ring.

Let me walk the room. Some of you are young, and you want a moment that reads as sacrifice. What you get is an ordinary hour, and nobody is filming it. Uh, a young man I know, Caleb, told me he'd take

a hit for the girl he's seeing. I asked if he could let her pick the long way home. He thought that was too small to count. He tried it on a roommate who was scared about a job. Caleb had the plan ready before the fear finished. The roommate said he didn't need the plan. He needed the end of the thought. If you have never lost a small preference, a ceremony will not teach your hands. Uh, if there is no wife yet, stay. The cross is not a wedding present. Somebody already in your life has a good that is not yours. Lose one small preference today. Give what they need, not what makes you look generous. If you're— if you're married, she already knows if you kept your life. Being right will not raise a house. Uh, if you're hurt, go slow. Don't lay it down as a lever to get her back. If the marriage ended, you may still be gripping a point you would not drop when you had the chance. Grieve that. Confess your part. Do the next true thing. Set down the sharper text you want to send the mother of your kids. A child reads your face at a school door. Stand beside her and talk about that child as two adults. If the years are long, you can buy a bigger grill and miss the woman beside it. Ask what she wants those years to be, then build that. Uh, if the work is going well, you can't purchase the dying. A fine night and a stiff menu can still be you, intact, paying for a feeling. She needs the man. The tab was never her.

Jesus said a line that sounds as if you lost. Matthew sixteen, verse twenty-five. For whoever wants to save their life will lose it, but whoever loses their life for me will find it.

You put the win down. Uh, a woman exhales, because she doesn't have to armor up before she tells you what is true. You put that private evening down. The house gets a little air. You put the hidden plan down. A future shows up she can actually stand in. Uh, none of that is wasted. The Father— the Father sees the fight you lost on purpose. He sees the hour you were tired and you stayed a person in it anyway. The pay that counts is His pay. God's pay. Not the thin nod from a good year of work. The Man who laid everything down will not shrug at a husband who laid a smaller thing down and aimed it the same direction. If this hits you and the bottom feels thin, hear me. A house can turn on this, slower than a speech, and more honest. She is not shopping for a stranger. She is asking the man she married to be in the room he already pays for. Uh, it happens in pieces, on days that will not become a story. If there is no wife, you don't get a pass. You are in the practice, and the practice is the real thing. Lose a preference. Uh, say one true sentence out loud. Stay to the end of somebody else's thought. What she reaches for is a smaller share of what Christ is to His people. He stays. He is near. He tells the truth and carries the weight close. A house can hold a little of that. The price is the man. She has been saying so in ways we keep renaming.

Let me put it where you can carry it. Headship is a cross. Men want the authority of Ephesians five without the giving up of Ephesians five. You can be right and lay it down, and that is the whole marriage. She does not need more of what you make. She needs you.

What I— what I hope you leave holding is one grip, in a full sentence, the line you are afraid she would say, and one thing you'll put down, day after day. If you only admire the cross, you'll keep your life and call it love. Uh, your workbook has the page. In a minute, uh, you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. Here are the questions. What do you grip hardest? Say it in a full sentence. What sister sentence are you afraid of? The one she would use with her sister, or the one she would have used, or, if there is no wife, the true line from somebody close. What will you lay down as you go, and what will you ask? Put that one thing down on purpose. Don't announce it. Don't keep a tally of it. Uh, ask her,

plain, what she needs from you that she is not getting. Hear her whole answer. Do the first thing she names while you can still say her words back. If you are single, lose a small preference, again and again, and practice one real need with the people already in your life. Tell a brother, you know, what you are laying down, and what she said. Ask him what he sees you holding. Ask if he has ever asked his wife. Write this where your eyes will hit it. Headship is a cross. You can be right and lay it down. She needs you. Same four marks you've carried all along. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Go on to your tables.